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# How CSOs can turn cybersecurity into a business growth strategy

Opinion

Aug 14, 2026 • 6 mins

The next evolution of cybersecurity leadership is moving from the team that says “no” to the team that helps organizations say “yes.”



*Credit: Ground Picture / Shutterstock*

For years, cybersecurity leaders have worked to convince organizations that security deserves a seat at the executive table. Today, that conversation is changing.

The challenge is no longer proving that cybersecurity matters; it is demonstrating how security leaders can help organizations innovate, modernize, and grow with confidence.

As organizations accelerate digital transformation, CSOs have an opportunity to redefine their role. Rather than serving primarily as defenders of technology, cybersecurity leaders are becoming strategic business partners who help shape operational decisions, influence technology investments, and build the trust required for innovation.

Making that transition requires more than technical expertise. It requires cybersecurity leaders to rethink how they communicate value and engage the business.

## Stop talking about security. Start talking about business outcomes.

Executive teams do not wake up thinking about firewalls, vulnerabilities, or compliance checklists. They think about growth, customer expectations, operational continuity, and delivering results. Cybersecurity leaders must be able to connect the two and translate cyber risk into business impact.

Most CSOs have probably heard some version of this: “Security is slowing us down.”

Changing that perception starts with changing the conversation. Security should not be viewed as the final checkpoint before launch; it should be part of the roadmap from day one.

The most effective security teams are not the ones that create the most friction. Instead, they help organizations move forward because leaders know risk is being managed along the way.

Security becomes far more influential when it is positioned as a catalyst for transformation rather than a cost of doing business.

## Build security into the business, not around it

The most effective cybersecurity programs are not created in isolation. They are built through partnership with the teams responsible for driving the business forward.

For CSOs, that means getting involved earlier, before technology decisions are finalized, before new platforms are deployed, and before security becomes a last-minute review. It means building relationships with business leaders, understanding their priorities, and identifying where security can help them achieve their goals.

Whether supporting healthcare systems, research environments, educational institutions, or corporate workplaces, cybersecurity leaders should work alongside operational teams to understand how technology enables their work and where risks may emerge.

When security is part of the conversation from the beginning, teams can identify challenges earlier, make smarter decisions, and avoid costly changes later.

The goal is to shift the perception of cybersecurity from the team that creates obstacles to the team helping the organization move forward with confidence. The most effective CSOs do not just manage risk; they help the business take on new opportunities securely.

That shift also changes how the business views security. Instead of being the team that says “no,” cybersecurity becomes the team that helps the organization move forward safely.

## Make resilience the metric that matters

Successful cybersecurity leaders are increasingly measured by more than their ability to prevent incidents. The question is no longer only, “How do we stop something bad from happening?” It is also, “How quickly can we recover, adapt, and continue serving people when challenges arise?”

Cyber resilience has become a business capability because organizations are defined not only by how they prevent disruption, but by how they respond when disruption occurs.

Resilience looks different across industries, but the responsibility remains the same: helping organizations maintain critical operations and protect the people who depend on them.

For food and facilities management providers, that means supporting essential services across healthcare, education, research environments, and corporate environments. Technology underpins everything from patient care and research to workplace operations, meaning even a brief disruption can create significant operational and human consequences.

For CSOs, this creates an opportunity to reframe the conversation. Cybersecurity investments should not only be measured by what they prevent, but by the continuity, confidence, and resilience they enable across the organization.

## Design security people will actually use

The best cybersecurity programs do more than protect systems; they enable people to do their jobs more effectively. And the strongest security controls are often the ones employees barely notice.

If security introduces unnecessary complexity, people will find ways around it. But when protections are intuitive and seamlessly integrated into daily workflows, secure behavior becomes the default.

For CSOs, this means thinking beyond traditional security controls and focusing on how security enables the business. Identity management, secure access, automation, and user-centered design are not just technical investments; they are tools that help employees work more efficiently, adopt new technologies with confidence, and reduce friction across the organization.

Good cybersecurity is not simply about making systems more secure. It is about creating an environment where people can move faster, make better decisions, and innovate without unnecessary barriers.

When employees have access to the tools they need while protections operate seamlessly in the background, organizations can strengthen security while improving productivity and accelerating business outcomes.

# The CISO's role is expanding

Cybersecurity leaders are uniquely positioned to bridge technology and business strategy.

As organizations adopt AI increasingly, expand connected operations and modernize critical infrastructure, executive teams increasingly need security leaders who can influence strategy, not only manage risk.

That requires building relationships across the organization, understanding business priorities, speaking the language of the business, and demonstrating how cybersecurity enables innovation rather than constrains it.

Organizations will continue investing in digital transformation. The question is whether cybersecurity leaders choose to participate in shaping that transformation or simply respond to it.

The future of cybersecurity leadership is not about being the team that says no. It is about being the team that helps organizations say yes — with confidence. When security is designed into the way organizations operate, it becomes more than protection. It becomes a foundation for innovation, resilience and growth.

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